
ܡܝܬܬܐ ܕܐܕܡ • THE TESTAMENT OF ADAM

INTRODUCTION

The *Testament of Adam* is a short Christian, pseudepigraphal work from late antiquity; it was likely composed in Syriac, though it now survives in numerous languages and recensions.

The document is comprised of two main parts, usually called the *Horarium* and the *Prophecy* by modern scholars. It is conventionally divided into four chapters, with the *Horarium* comprising the first two chapters and the *Prophecy* as chapter three. What we often call the fourth chapter is an additional section, the *Hierarchy*, which only appears in one manuscript (*Vatican Syriac 164*, dated at 1072 CE) and was almost certainly not part of any original document.

The Syriac (*BM Add. 14,624*, early 9th Century CE, Chs 1–3 only) and Greek (*Paris Codex Greek 2419*, 15th/16th Century) texts here presented are from the [Online Critical Pseudepigrapha](#) (OCP). Note that the order of Chs 1 & 2 in the Greek text here cited is inverted in respect of that of the Syriac text. The Syriac text for Ch. 4 is a version of M. Kmosko's 1907 transcription of 'Fragment 3' and may contain errors.

AUTHORSHIP AND DATES

There is no consensus about the dating of the *Testament of Adam*. The earliest known manuscript is from the 9th Century CE (Syriac, as presented here) and the combining of the *Horarium* and the *Prophecy* must have happened sometime before that. If the text of *Transitus Mariae* that Lewis edited is from the 5th Century, as she was led to believe, this might be the earliest witness, or at least to the *Prophecy*. In the Coptic *Apocalypse of Elijah* (3:1–8), a list of the antichrist's miracles is found that resembles the list of Jesus' miracles in 3:1. On this basis, some tentatively suggest that the *Prophecy* was composed in the 3rd Century CE and dates the *Horarium* no later than that, though possibly earlier. James Charlesworth believes that the work evidences many features that suggest a date of composition in the late 2nd Century CE but he only points specifically to the motif of Cain's jealousy over his sister (3:5) as a possible expression of early Syrian asceticism.

תְּסֻמָּת אָדָם ב

1 הַשָּׁעָה הַרְּבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַשָּׁמַיִת. 2 הַשָּׁעָה הַשֵּׁנִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַמַּלְאָכִית. 3 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁלִישִׁית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית. 4 הַשָּׁעָה הָרְבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַבְּהֵמָיִית. 5 הַשָּׁעָה הַחֲמִישִׁית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַשָּׁמַיִת הַנִּשְׁמָה. 6 הַשָּׁעָה הַשִּׁשִּ�ית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַנִּשְׁמָה. 7 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַנִּשְׁמָה. 8 הַשָּׁעָה הַחֲמִישִׁית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַנִּשְׁמָה. 9 הַשָּׁעָה הַשִּׁשִּ�ית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַנִּשְׁמָה. 10 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַנִּשְׁמָה.

TESTAMENT OF ADAM 2

1 The first hour of the day is the petition of the heavenly ones. 2 The second hour is the prayer of the angels. 3 The third hour is the praise of the birds. 4 The fourth hour is the praise of the beasts. 5 The fifth hour is the praise that is above heaven. 6 The sixth hour is the praise of the cherubim who plead against the sin of our human nature. 7 The seventh hour is the entry and exit from the presence of God, when the prayers of all living things enter and they worship and depart. 8 The eighth hour is the praise of fire and of the waters. 9 The ninth hour is the entreaty of those angels who stand before the throne of majesty. 10 The tenth hour is the visitation of the waters when the spirit descends and broods on the waters and on the fountains. And, if the spirit of the Lord did not descend and brood on the waters and on the fountains, human beings would be injured and everyone the demons saw they would injure. And at that hour the waters (are)

TESTAMENT OF ADAM 2

- 1 The Greek text for this verse, as quoted by Cedrenus, reads, "At the first hour of the day, the first prayer is said in heaven." (ὥρα πρώτη ἡμερινῇ πρώτη εὐχή ἐπιτελεῖται ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ.)
- 2 Cedrenus has just, "The second is for the angels." (δευτέρῃ εὐχῇ ἀγγέλων.)
- 3 Here, Cedrenus concurs with the Syriac MSS, reading, "The third is for the prayer of birds." (τρίτῃ εὐχῇ πτηνῶν.)
- 4 Cedrenus has, "The fourth is for the prayer of animals." (τετάρτῃ εὐχῇ κτηνῶν.)
- 5 Cedrenus appears to repeat v. 4 here, reading, "The fifth is for the prayer of beasts." (πεμπτῇ εὐχῇ θηρίων.) Cf. #4.
- 6 Cedrenus reads, "The sixth, the angels defend and judge all creation." (ἕκτῃ ἀγγέλων παράστασις καὶ διάκρισις πάσης κτίσεως.)
- 7 Cedrenus here reads, "The seventh, is the angels entry and exit from God." (ἑβδόμῃ ἀγγέλων εἴσοδος πρὸς θεὸν καὶ ἔξοδος ἀγγέλων.)
- 8 Cedrenus has, "The eighth is [for the] praise and sacrifice of the angels." (ὀγδόῃ αἵνεσις καὶ θυσίαι ἀγγέλων.)
- 9 Cedrenus has, "The ninth [is when] the worship of men is born." (ἐννάτῃ δέησις καὶ λατρεία ἀνθρώπου.)
- 10 For this verse, Cedrenus reads, "The tenth, bishops of the waters and prayers of heavenly and earthly beings." (δεκάτῃ ἐπισκοπαὶ ὑδάτων καὶ δεήσεις οὐρανίων καὶ ἐπιγείων.)

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taken up and the priest of God mixes them with consecrated oil and
 anoints those who are afflicted and they are restored and healed.
¹¹ The eleventh hour is the exultation and joy of the righteous. ¹² The
 twelfth hour, the hour of the evening, is the entreaty of human
 beings, for the gracious will of God, the Lord of all.

¹¹ Cedrenus reads, “The eleventh, confession and joy of all.” (ένδεκάτη ἀνθομολόγησις καὶ ἀγαλλίασις πάντων.)

¹² Cedrenus ends his quotation here, with, “The twelfth, resistance[?] of people to good fortune.” (δωδεκάτη ἔντευξις ἀνθρώπων εἰς εὐδοκίας.)

4 * אֲנִי אֶלֶּה אֶתְּכֶם וְאֶתְּכֶם
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5. עֲבַדְתָּ כִּי, שָׁמַע. וְנִסְחָתָא אֶפְסָא מִשְׁעָרָא
לְחַלְמִי. כִּי־חָכָא חֲפָלָא בְּתוֹכָא מִכָּא אֶפְסָא וְחֲפָלָא
וְלִבְנִי. וְשָׁמַע אֶפְסָא לְמַכְלֵל אֶפְסָא. כִּי, וְנִסְחָתָא
נִסְחָתָא אֶפְסָא תְּלִמְתָּא. אֶפְסָא מִכָּא אֶפְסָא מִכָּא
לְמַכְלֵל. שָׁמַע אֶפְסָא וְנִסְחָתָא ❖ מִכָּא

[illegible]

⁴ Reeves has '*descendants*' in place of '*seed*'.

⁶ The '*Cave of Treasures*' is used as a title of a work that includes much of this document, along with many other texts.

❖ אֵלֹהִים וְיֵשׁוּעַ וְכָל הַשְּׁמַיִם

[illegible]

Also, the Testament of Our Father, Adam

³ The second order is the sacrifice of archangels. This is the service: directing everything in this creation according to the plan of God, whether powers, or animals, or birds, or creeping things, or fish, as in their divisions, and to speak briefly and in short, whatever exists in this creation, except for human beings, they care for it and guide it.

⁴ The third order, which is the archons. This is its service: moving the air so that a cloud rises from the ends of the earth, according to the words of David the prophet, and rain falls upon the earth. And this

1 The 'unrepresentable characters' in vv. 1-2 were introduced during the image-to-text conversion process; they may simply be a matter of using an inappropriate font, and the matter is under investigation.

2 Kmosko starts a new paragraph with this (and each) verse.

3 The 'published translation' does not have '*sacrifice of*' or '*as in their divisions*'.

4 It is not completely clear what/who is referred to by '*Archons*'.

וְהָיָה כִּי יִשְׁלַח אֱלֹהִים מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם
 לְהַלְלֵךְ הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר
 הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר
 הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר

(order) makes all the variations in the atmosphere, sometimes rain and sometimes snow and sometimes hail and sometimes dust and sometimes blood. And it varies them. These also belong to this (order): thunder and the fire of lightning.

וְהָיָה כִּי יִשְׁלַח אֱלֹהִים מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם
 לְהַלְלֵךְ הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר
 הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר
 הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר

⁵ The fourth order, which is authorities. This is its service: the administration of the luminaries, of the sun and the moon and the stars.

וְהָיָה כִּי יִשְׁלַח אֱלֹהִים מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם
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 הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר
 הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר

⁶ The fifth order, which is the powers. This is its service: they keep the demons from destroying the creation of God out of their jealousy toward human beings; for, if the evil nature of the demons were allowed to accomplish the lust of its will, in an hour and a moment they would overthrow the whole creation. But the divine power stops them; for, a watch is set over them lest they succeed in achieving the desire of their will.

וְהָיָה כִּי יִשְׁלַח אֱלֹהִים מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם
 לְהַלְלֵךְ הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר הַמָּלְאָכִים לְהַזְכִּיר
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⁷ The sixth order, which is the dominions. This is its service: they rule over kingdoms, and in their hands are victory and defeat in battle. And this is shown (to be) so by (the example of) the Assyrian king. For when he went up against Jerusalem, an angel descended and ravaged the camp of the wicked, and one hundred eighty-five thousand died in one moment. And also, the blessed Zechariah saw the angel in the form of a man riding on a red horse standing among the trees of the tabernacle and following him (were others on) white and red horses with lances in their hands. And Judas Maccabeus also saw the angel

⁵ The 'published translation' has 'lights' in place of 'luminaries'.

⁶ The 'published translation' has 'cursed' in place of 'evil'.

⁷ In place of 'Judas Maccabeus', the 'published translation' has 'Judah the Maccabee'.

